overs didn’t make sense to us, and we knew we were up against it. Effectively the target to win had become stiffer. On the other hand, to qualify, we only needed 100 runs.

Anshuman Gaekwad, a former India opening batsman and then our coach, was in charge of the calculations and I asked him the exact target before I went out to resume the innings. Several of my team-mates thought we should just concentrate on getting the 100 runs we needed for qualification and not risk our place in the final by going for the win. However, I was determined to win the match and go to the finals, because I was timing the ball well and felt good about my batting. And beating Australia would give us an edge over them in the final.

It was important not to let the Australian bowlers settle. I hit Tom Moody for a six as soon as the game resumed, making my intentions clear. I followed it up with another six off Warne and attacked the Australians in every over I faced. They were doing their best to keep me off strike, while my partner VVS Laxman was doing his best to make sure I faced the bulk of the bowling. Looking back, I feel I owe him an apology as at one point I lost my temper with him when he refused a second run, thinking I was in danger of getting run out. I just wanted to play every ball I could.

When we passed 200 I started to feel that the Australian score was within reach. I was determined to bat on and finish the game. I have to say that if I had not got out to a dubious decision by the umpire with three overs still left in the game, I think we would probably have chased down the Australian score. I was given out to Damien Fleming, caught by Gilchrist for 143, when the ball seemed to me to be above shoulder height and should have been declared a no-ball. But such things happen in cricket and in the end we lost the game but qualified for the final and still had a chance for revenge.

Thinking of this match reminds me of a story about Anshuman Gaekwad. I have very fond memories of Anshu bhai as our coach and he undoubtedly had a very positive influence and helped me in a number of ways, but I can also never forget his amazing capacity to eat the hottest of hot food. On one occasion in New Zealand in 1999 he asked the hotel chef to make a paste of green chillies for him. The chef took on the challenge and returned later with a fresh bowl of chilli paste, warning him that he should be careful only to have a little because it was extremely hot. To the chef’s amazement, Anshu bhai gratefully took the